

Ziphius cavirostris

Cuvier's beaked whale



Location Temperate and tropical waters worldwide

Length 20–23 ft (6–7 m)
Weight 2½–3½ tons (2.5–3.5 tonnes)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

and other creatures using suction (see northern bottlenose whale, p.259). The jawline curves up at the tip of the snout and then down. Along with the relatively smooth forehead, this leads to the alternative name of goose-beak whale. The small flippers fit into indentations in the body so that the

whale is streamlined for fast swimming, using only its tail flukes, down to great depths. The pale brown to blue-gray body is scarred by parasites and also, in males, by bites from males of the same species. These wounds probably occur during dominance battles at breeding time. Older male

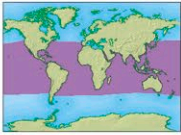
Cuvier's beaked whales tend to live alone. Most males have 2 cone-shaped teeth, which project like tusks from the lower jaw. Females and young are toothless. Younger males, females, and offspring, which are nearly 9 ft (2.7 m) long at birth, form schools of rarely more than 10.



This species has the long, slim body and small dorsal fin set well to the rear typical of the beaked whale family. It feeds on deep-living squid

Kogia simus

Dwarf sperm whale



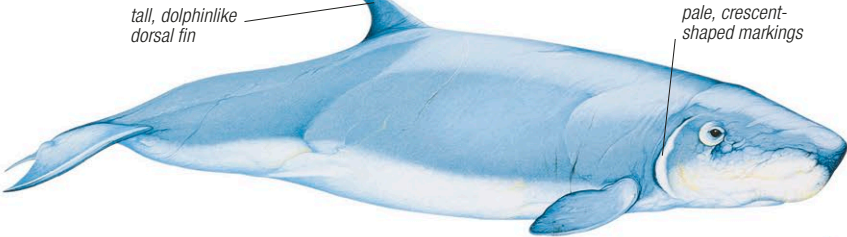
Location Temperate and tropical waters worldwide

Length 8¼ ft (2.7 m)
Weight 300–620 lb (135–280 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Data deficient

Smallest of the 3 species of sperm whales, this whale dives to nearly 1,000 ft (300 m) for fish, squid, crustaceans, and mollusks. The lower jaw has 8–13 pairs of sharp teeth, and is slung almost sharklike under the large, bulbous head; the upper jaw has only 3 pairs of teeth. Back, fin, flippers, and flukes are blue-gray, shading to cream below. Just behind the mouth and eye is a contrasting, pale crescent, which, in size and position, resembles the gill slit of a fish. A shy creature, the

dwarf sperm whale lives alone or in small schools (fewer than 10), and releases a cloud of feces to repel predators. Little is known about its breeding habits: the gestation period

appears to vary between 9 and 11 months, and the single calf, about 3 ft (1 m) long, is usually born in autumn. These whales seem prone to group strandings.



Physeter catodon

Sperm whale



Location Deep waters worldwide

Length 34–63 ft (10.4–19.2 m)
Weight 69 tons (Up to 70 tonnes)
Social unit Individual/Group
Status Vulnerable

deep dives may be in part due to its spermaceti organ (see panel, right). Between dives, the whale lies loglike at the surface, a plume of misty air emerging with each exhalation at 45 degrees from the single blowhole. The long, narrow lower jaw is slung under the huge head and bears 26 pairs of conical, round-tipped teeth; there are no visible upper teeth. The main color is dark gray or brown, paler on the underside, with white or cream around the lower jaw. Bull (male) sperm whales are twice the weight of females (cows) and tend to migrate farther north and south, into colder waters, for summer feeding. They form loose, bachelor pods when young but then become more solitary. Females stay nearer the tropics and form mixed groups with their young and juveniles to about 10 years old. In summer or autumn, after a gestation period of 14–15 months, the single calf is born, 13 ft (4 m) long, and suckles for 4 years or more.



KEEPING IN TOUCH
Sperm whales often swim near, touch, and caress others in their school. They also produce loud, rhythmic clicking and banging sounds, which may aid individual recognition.

SPERMACETI ORGAN

The sperm whale's enormous head contains a spermaceti organ—a large mass of waxy oil. It was thought to work as a buoyancy aid, becoming denser with changing temperature and pressure, to assist very deep dives. However, its function is now considered to be that of a focussing lens for echolocation.



LARGE HEAD

The sperm whale's tall, narrow, boxlike head comprises up to one-third of its total length. The low dorsal fin is set well to the rear.

